country . . . Today, after four years, all our friends have deserted us. We have no friends left. We have alienated ourselves.' [15] Other opponents of Nehru—from Acharya Kripalani to the Jan Sangh—espoused still different views on international affairs in the 1940s and 1950s. [16] But before India's leaders had an opportunity to engage in big debates about India's place in the world, there were some urgent problems that had to be negotiated in the first few weeks and months after Independence.

Imperfect Unity: Territorial Consolidation, 1947–1961

The most immediate and important set of foreign policy challenges related to how India would address the consequences of Britain's departure and the Partition of India into two countries: India and Pakistan. These were existential problems in nature, as they would determine the physical contours and demographic constitution of independent India. The process was complicated enough given that Pakistan would be constituted of a geographically separate West Pakistan and East Pakistan, requiring divisions in Punjab and Bengal. But the status of the almost 600 'princely states' that recognized British paramountcy was vague when the plans for Independence and Partition were finalized in 1946 and 1947. Several states flirted with autonomy or accession to Pakistan, including Jodhpur and Travancore, while others such as Bhopal, Indore, and Mysore expressed reservations about acceding to India. Secretary of the Ministry of States V.P. Menon and Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel led the effort to offer states accession to India. An Instrument of Accession was drafted whereby such states would retain some autonomy, but transfer responsibility for external relations, defence, and communications to the Dominion of India. By April 1947, several major states such as Baroda, Jaipur, Cochin, and Patiala joined the Constituent Assembly. By 15 August 1947, the status of all but a handful of states contiguous to India had been determined in India's favour, including some such as Travancore, Indore and Bhopal that had previously proved reluctant. [17]